BJM BRITISH JOURNAL of MANAGEMENT
BRITISH ACADEMY OF MANAGEMENT
British Journal of Management, Vol. 35, 1592–1608 (2024)
DOI: 10.1111/1467-8551.12774

More Social, More Socially Responsible? The Impact of CEO Social Media Use on Corporate Social Performance

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Nowadays, more and more firm chief executive officers (CEOs) are using social media to join online conversations and interact with stakeholders. As this social media presence shows their social participation tendencies, such CEOs have been described as 'social CEOs'. Building on an upper-echelon perspective of corporate social responsibility (CSR), this study examines whether social CEOs and the implications of their social media engagement have an impact on corporate social performance by developing a needs–affordances–consequences approach. Our approach explores the motives and ability of social CEOs, suggesting the positive influence of CEO sociability on CSR and also the moderating effect of CEOs' social evaluation. Using data on Chinese publicly listed firms from 2009 to 2020, we find that firms with social CEOs have a higher level of social performance than firms without, and higher CEO status or better CEO reputation can further amplify the positive impact of CEO sociability on corporate social performance. This work makes important contributions to research on the determinants of CSR, as well as the social media and leadership literature.

Introduction

Given the profound economic and social impact of corporate social responsibility (CSR) on firms and stakeholders (He, Kim and Gustafsson, 2021; Hoi, Wu and Zhang, 2013; Price and Sun, 2017), there is growing research interest in the determinants of CSR to understand what drives it. A considerable emphasis in the literature has been the adoption of an upper-echelons perspective to explore how firms' social behaviour is shaped by top managers, and especially chief executive officers (CEOs) as the main representatives (Bertrand, Betschinger and Moschieri, 2021; Chin, Hambrick and Treviño, 2013; Hambrick, 2007; Hambrick and Mason, 1984; Hrazdil, Mahmoudian and Nazari, 2021; Wei, Ouyang and Chen, 2018). These CSR researchers have largely built on the traditional or common CEO characteristics documented in the upper-echelons literature to examine managerial predictors of CSR effort, such as CEO demographics, experiences and personality traits (Arena, Michelon and Trojanowski, 2018; Bouzouitina, Khaireddine and Jarboui, 2021; Ho *et al.*, 2015; Janani *et al.*, 2022; Lewis, Walls and Dowell, 2014; McGuinness, Vieito and Wang, 2017; O'Sullivan, Zolotoy and Fan, 2021; Petrenko *et al.*, 2016; Tang *et al.*, 2015; Q. Wang and Yan, 2023; Zhang, Xu and Chen, 2022). While CSR activities are more about the social influence on firms' stakeholders and external interactions with society (Campbell, 2007; Liu *et al.*, 2021), little attention has been paid to CEOs' social attributes that shape their willingness and ability in social engagement. In particular, CEO sociability as a trait showing social participation tendency may provide significant explanation for firms' social contributions. However, probably because of the great difficulty of reaching CEOs to survey their sociability (Hrazdil, Mahmoudian and Nazari, 2021), scholars tend to evade this managerial trait, leaving an important gap in both upper echelons and CSR research.

The rise of public social media provides us with an alternative channel for observing and capturing the trait of CEO sociability by presenting the social engagement of CEOs (Heavey *et al.*, 2020; Q. Wang, Lau and Xie, 2021; Weber Shandwick, 2014). The CEOs with social media participation are described as social CEOs, who are willing to interact with the public (Erdoğmuş and Esen, 2018; Weber Shandwick, 2014). In the present study, we focus on CEO sociability to

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explore its implications for corporate social performance (CSP). To comprehensively understand CEO sociability and its further reflection in CSR, we develop a specialized needs–affordances–consequences approach to social CEOs by drawing insights from social media use research and leadership literature (Heavey *et al.*, 2020; Karahanna *et al.*, 2018; Leonardi and Vaast, 2017; Sheldon, Abad and Hinsch, 2011). Based on psychological needs for social influence and belonging, the unique affordances in stakeholder reach and information communication as well as the visibility consequences of CEOs' social media engagement, we suggest that social CEOs have stronger motives and ability to engage their firms in social contributions compared to their unsocial counterparts. Since the external social evaluation of CEOs may further influence their social interaction by shaping their needs, affordances and consequences (Bitektine, 2011; Fralich and Bitektine, 2020; George *et al.*, 2016; Liu *et al.*, 2021), we also propose that the positive effect of CEO sociability on CSP is more prominent for CEOs with a higher level of social status or reputation. Using a sample of Chinese listed firms between 2009 and 2020, we investigate the participation of their CEOs on one of the most influential social media platforms – Weibo, a public blogging platform, and find substantial support for the hypotheses.

Our study offers three contributions to the literature. First, we provide unique insights into the determinants of CSR by demonstrating that social CEOs are more socially responsible. Past studies mainly examined the managerial predictors of CSR by following established characteristics in the upper-echelons literature (Hambrick, 2007; Lewis, Walls and Dowell, 2014; McGuinness, Vieito and Wang, 2017; Wei, Ouyang and Chen, 2018; Zhang, Xu and Chen, 2022). In particular, unlike the self-evaluation characteristics of firm leaders (e.g. hubris and narcissism), sociability highlights the personality traits of the interaction with society (Erdoğmuş and Esen, 2018; Heavey *et al.*, 2020; Weber Shandwick, 2014), but little is known about its impact on firms' social behaviour outcomes. We thus propose and theorize CEO sociability as a powerful driver of CSP by taking advantage of CEOs' social media participation to observe their sociability. By doing so, the present study demonstrates a previously overlooked and distinguishable CEO social trait that shapes firm social behaviour based on upper-echelons theory.

Second, we extend extant knowledge of the implications of CEO social media engagement for firm outcomes. Some prior research has shown the effect of executives' social media use on the information communication of firms, which further affects corporate financial outcomes (Elliott, Grant and Hodge, 2018; Feng and Johansson, 2019; Q. Wang, Lau and Xie, 2021). Meanwhile, while the social media literature has emphasized the importance of CEO social media use in connecting to and influencing stakeholders (Heavey *et al.*, 2020), there is a dearth of studies on its role in firm outcomes in the social domain. Adopting an upper-echelons perspective, we consider social media engagement as an indicator of CEO sociability, reflecting the needs, affordances and consequences for CEOs and thereby shaping firm social outcomes. We thus provide a new conceptual understanding for the nascent literature on CEO social media use and firm outcomes.

Third, our integrative needs–affordances–consequences approach to social CEOs also contributes to the social media and leadership literature by highlighting the comprehensive investigation of three aspects of leaders' social media use. We draw on insights from social media research and meanwhile account for CEOs' identity to develop this integrative framework to understand social CEOs (Heavey *et al.*, 2020; Karahanna *et al.*, 2018; Leonardi and Vaast, 2017; Sheldon, Abad and Hinsch, 2011), thus offering a comprehensive and rich lens for the literature.

The rest of the paper is organized as follows. The next section reviews the literature and develops our hypotheses. In the third section, the sample and data, measures of variables and econometric models are described. The fourth section presents our estimation results, including supplemental analyses and robustness checks. The last section offers discussion and conclusions.

Literature review and hypothesis development

Upper echelons and CSR

Upper-echelons theory suggests that the organization is a reflection of its top executives, who interpret situations and make strategic choices for the organization according to their values and cognitive biases (Hambrick, 2007; Hambrick and Mason, 1984). Organizational outcomes can therefore be explained by executives' personal characteristics associated with their experiences, values and personalities. Based on this theory, top executives can set the ethical tone of a firm and make decisions about CSR engagement (Saha *et al.*, 2020; Zhao *et al.*, 2023), thereby shaping the social performance of the firm. Since 'the CEO is generally seen as the firm's main representative' (Bertrand, Betschinger and Moschieri, 2021, p. 535), prior CSR work has addressed the impacts of CEOs' demographical and background characteristics on CSR performance, including gender (Ho *et al.*, 2015; McGuinness, Vieito and Wang, 2017), education (Lewis, Walls and Dowell, 2014) and foreignness (Bertrand, Betschinger and Moschieri, 2021). Similarly, as individual experiences greatly influence the personalized interpretation of strategic situations, scholars have unveiled the role of CEOs' overseas (Zhang, Xu and Chen, 2022), disaster (O'Sullivan, Zolotoy and Fan,

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2021) and marketing experiences (Janani *et al.*, 2022) in driving CSR engagement. Moreover, recent CSR researchers have also shed light on some of the most common psychological traits of CEOs, such as their narcissism and hubris (Bouzouitina, Khaireddine and Jarboui, 2021; Petrenko *et al.*, 2016; Tang *et al.*, 2015).

However, differing from other organizational-level outcomes, CSR is more about responding to stakeholder demands and benefitting social welfare (Campbell, 2007), which involves interaction with stakeholders and external influences on society. Therefore, among individual characteristics, the sociability of CEOs may provide greater explanation for their CSR involvement. In particular, sociability is a prominent social-related trait that shows individual social engagement tendency, and especially a willingness to connect to society and interact with stakeholders (Erdoğmuş and Esen, 2018; S. Nadkarni and Herrmann, 2010; Q. Wang, Lau and Xie, 2021). Such a characteristic may therefore more accurately indicate CEOs' motives and ability for social contributions. However, with the challenge of reaching firms' top executives and the difficulties of capturing the underlying traits (Hrazdil, Mahmoudian and Nazari, 2021), the existing upper-echelons research is almost silent on whether and how CEO sociability shapes their firms' CSR outcomes.

The emergence of public social media platforms enables the observation of CEOs' sociability, since they can choose whether or not to leverage social media to engage in social interactions with stakeholders and the general public online. Those who use social media are viewed as social CEOs (Tsai and Men, 2017; Weber Shandwick, 2014). Thus, to investigate CEO sociability and explore its implications for CSR, we focus on the presence and engagement of CEOs on social media and discuss how this social engagement behaviour predicts CSP.

Social CEOs and CSR

As social media is widely used by people to interact with the outside world, the social media literature has focused on 'social' individuals and discussed the potential causes and consequences of people having social interactions on public platforms (Junglas *et al.*, 2013; Leonardi and Vaast, 2017; Miles and Mangold, 2014; Treem and Leonardi, 2013). For example, from a psychological perspective, Karahanna *et al.* (2018) theorize about individuals' inner needs motivating their social media use and the affordances enabled by it. Nevertheless, compared to ordinary users, social CEOs as the spokespersons of firms are expected to have distinguishing features among social media users (Huang and Yeo, 2018; S. Wang and Chen, 2020), for example, being in greater need of social influence and impression management (Heavey *et al.*, 2020). As such, we adopt a needs–affordances–consequences approach to social CEOs, which integrates the views on individuals' social media usage in the literature and meanwhile considers social CEOs' identity and position. This more contextualized approach is further taken to explain the specific motivations and ability of social CEOs for engaging in CSR.

At the needs level, social influence need is one of the most important psychological needs motivating firm leaders' presence on social media (Heavey *et al.*, 2020), as social media offers them a public stage for self-presentation and impression management (Etter, Ravasi and Colleoni, 2019; Karaduman, 2013; A. Nadkarni and Hofmann, 2012; Nolan, 2015). Social CEOs, who are more willing to present themselves in public and impact others than unsocial CEOs, therefore care more about their social image and reputation (Alghawi, Yan and Wei, 2014; Kietzmann *et al.*, 2011). The social influence need behind social media engagement is in line with one of the motives for CSR engagement, because the CSR literature has extensively discussed image building and reputation improvement as outcomes of CSR engagement (Fombrun and Shanley, 1990; Park, Lee and Kim, 2014; Williams and Barrett, 2000; B. Wu *et al.*, 2021). Thus, the need for social influence of social CEOs tends to motivate their involvement in CSR.

Another significant psychological need pertinent to social media use is the need for relatedness and belonging (Karahanna *et al.*, 2018; A. Nadkarni and Hofmann, 2012; Sheldon, Abad and Hinsch, 2011). For firm leaders, social media facilitates the 'connective and communal interaction' between themselves and stakeholders (Heavey *et al.*, 2020, p. 1493). Compared to their unsocial counterparts, CEOs using social media tend to be more concerned about 'what's going on in the world' and seek a link with society (Q. Wang, Lau and Xie, 2021; Weber Shandwick, 2014). This type of need indicates the motivations for interacting with, being connected to and experiencing caring for others (Deci and Ryan, 1991), implying individuals' prosocial tendency (Pavey, Greitemeyer and Sparks, 2011). As a prosocial behaviour, CSR is a common strategic means of building relationships and bonds with stakeholders (Bendixen and Abratt, 2007; Dmytriyev, Freeman and Hörisch, 2021; Elms and Phillips, 2009), which can satisfy the relatedness need of social CEOs. Thus, from the perspective of individual needs, social media engagement is potentially motivated by the social influence and relatedness needs of CEOs. The two types of psychological needs of social CEOs can meanwhile function as their inner motives for CSR involvement, driving them to contribute more value to society for the branding and belonging effects of CSR that meet their needs.

The affordance lens on social media use further suggests the benefits and abilities of social CEOs afforded by the new technology for communication (Heavey

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et al., 2020; Leonardi and Vaast, 2017; Majchrzak *et al.*, 2013). Openness to information and knowledge is one of the most powerful affordances of social media as an interactive communication tool (Baptista *et al.*, 2017; Leonardi and Vaast, 2017). This affordance can equip CEOs with a stronger ability for information processing – 'to inform, update, and exchange knowledge with stakeholders' (Heavey *et al.*, 2020, p. 1494). For example, social CEOs can initiate dialogue with online stakeholders to solicit feedback, as the CEO of Airbnb (Brian Chesky) used Twitter to post on 2 January 2022: 'If @Airbnb could launch anything in 2022, what would it be?'. He received thousands of ideas from the online public, including CSR-related suggestions (e.g. helping to promote local community culture). In addition to the participation in online dialogue, firm CEOs – as witnesses to conversations on social media – also benefit from their access to Big Data in real time (Kietzmann *et al.*, 2011; Q. Wang, Lau and Xie, 2021), making them more informed than unsocial CEOs. This social media affordance leads to greater stakeholder reach and information superiority, allowing social CEOs to better respond to the demands of stakeholders and perform better at CSR.

As for the consequences of CEOs' social media use, higher visibility has been demonstrated as a direct outcome of this social engagement behaviour (Huang and Yeo, 2018; Leonardi, 2014; Weber Shandwick, 2014). Similar to other public exposure, such as media coverage (Godos-Díez *et al.*, 2020; Graf-Vlachy *et al.*, 2020; Kang and Han Kim, 2017; Zyglidopoulos *et al.*, 2012), CEOs' presence on public open social media platforms can garner large-scale attention from online audiences. Because of social media's advantages in terms of speed and range of information dissemination (Feng and Johansson, 2019), CEOs' presence on social media can attract much more public attention than on traditional media. This greater attention means higher social visibility of CEOs and their firms, suggesting that their behaviour is under heightened public scrutiny and stronger social pressure (Godos-Díez *et al.*, 2020; Liu *et al.*, 2021). As documented in the CSR literature, public pressure is regarded as an extrinsic factor causing CSR activities (Zyglidopoulos *et al.*, 2012). For social CEOs, the public have one more alternative and effective channel to monitor them doing bad or good in society, resulting in higher pressure on them to behave in a socially acceptable way.

In short, based on our needs–affordances–consequences approach to CEOs' social media use, their main psychological needs of 'social influence' and 'relatedness' may reflect the intrinsic willingness of social CEOs to contribute to society, while the consequence for their visibility implies extrinsic motivation forcing them to behave in a socially responsible way. Meanwhile, the affordances of using social media – like information and communication advantages – can enhance their ability to benefit stakeholders. As a result, both the motives and ability of social CEOs to engage in CSR are expected to be stronger than those of their unsocial counterparts, resulting in better CSR outcomes. We therefore hypothesize:

H1: Firms with social CEOs have a higher level of CSP than firms without.

The moderating effect of social evaluation

According to upper-echelons theory, external forces in the environment can further shape managerial perceptions, impacting how much managerial characteristics are reflected in firm strategy and performance (Hambrick, 2007). In our context, firm CEOs as social actors are embedded in a socially interacted environment consisting of inter-relationships and mutual influence (Dmytriyev, Freeman and Hörisch, 2021; Heavey *et al.*, 2020). As such, in their interactions with stakeholders, CEOs are not only driven by their inner personal sociability, but also further subject to social forces from the environment. For example, the stakeholder community and society at large can evaluate firm leaders to form external perceptions and social judgement (Bitektine, 2011; George *et al.*, 2016; Washington and Zajac, 2005). Based on this theory, when CEOs perceive and interpret their social evaluation, the managerial perceptions can externally influence their motives and ability to interact with society (Liu *et al.*, 2021), which affects the reflection of their sociability in firms' decisions and behaviour concerning CSR.

There are two main forms of social evaluation in the literature – status and reputation. Specifically, status is the relative position or standing within the social order (George *et al.*, 2016; Wejnert, 2002), emphasizing the act of social acceptation (Bitektine, 2011). Reputation is defined as 'beliefs or perceptions held about the quality of a focal actor' (George *et al.*, 2016, p. 1), focusing on the differences and comparisons among individuals. Both higher-level status and reputation lead to two major impacts on CEOs: the 'being in the spotlight' effect and the Matthew effect (Liu *et al.*, 2021; Merton, 1968). The 'being in the spotlight' effect suggests that the greater social acceptance and favour resulting from the higher evaluation of firm CEOs tends to put them in the spotlight, with a greater level of attention and positive emotional responses from the public (Magee and Galinsky, 2008; Rindova, Pollock and Hayward, 2006; Wei, Ouyang and Chen, 2018). The Matthew effect demonstrates the comparative advantages of CEOs with good reputation and high status, because of their access to valuable resources (Bothner, Kim and Smith, 2012; Graffin *et al.*, 2008). Below, we discuss how these two mechanisms of social evaluation externally affect the needs, affordances and

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consequences of social CEOs, and thus influence their willingness and ability to engage in CSR.

At the needs level, when social CEOs have relatively good reputation or high status, to match their social favour and maintain their position of social acceptance in the spotlight, they are in greater need of impression management through social interactions (Kietzmann *et al.*, 2011; Rindova, Pollock and Hayward, 2006). Thus, the 'being in the spotlight' effect can amplify the social influence needs of social media use, which strengthens the relationship between CEO sociability and CSR effort. By contrast, the public holds relatively negative attitudes towards CEOs with a bad reputation, or pays less attention to low-status CEOs (Fralich and Bitektine, 2020; Reuber and Fischer, 2010; Sohn, Weaver Lariscy and Tinkham, 2009). This lower social evaluation tends to impair the motives of social CEOs for connecting to the public and influencing others. Since the lower social evaluation decreases those psychological needs of social CEOs, the CEOs are less willing to make social contributions.

For the ability of social CEOs, social media affords them openness to information and the convenience of stakeholder communication. Due to the 'being in the spotlight' effect, the social media engagement of CEOs with higher status or reputation tends to receive more online discussion related to them and their firms (Heavey *et al.*, 2020), so they can enjoy more information affordance and wider stakeholder reach. Moreover, higher status and better reputation facilitate social CEOs gaining resources from key stakeholders because of the Matthew effect (Bothner, Kim and Smith, 2012; Fralich and Bitektine, 2020), making executives better utilize the information affordances of social media to respond to social demands. For example, with access to political resources and social capital (H. Wang and Qian, 2011), the information processing and stakeholder reach of social CEOs can be strengthened to fulfil social responsibilities, for example, by conveying public demands to the government (Liu *et al.*, 2021). Hence, with a higher level of social evaluation, social CEOs can benefit from more information affordance and better leverage it in CSR activities, resulting in better CSR performance.

Visibility as the major consequence of CEOs' social media engagement is the extrinsic motivation for their CSR efforts. For social CEOs with higher social ranking or reputation, the 'spotlight' can raise stakeholder attention and expectations on social media (Graffin *et al.*, 2008; Piazza and Castellucci, 2014), further increasing the visibility of social CEOs and enhancing public scrutiny. Therefore, higher social evaluation also augments the extrinsic pressure for CEOs on social media, which amplifies the role of CEO sociability in CSR. To summarize, when social CEOs have higher levels of status or reputation, the 'being in the spotlight' effect and the Matthew effect are identified, strengthening their motives and ability to engage in CSR. We therefore propose:

H2: The higher the status of CEOs, the greater the positive effect of CEO sociability on CSP.
H3: The better the reputation of CEOs, the greater the positive effect of CEO sociability on CSP.

Data and method

Sample and data source

Our sample is constructed of Chinese firms publicly listed on the Shanghai or Shenzhen Stock Exchanges between 2009 and 2020. The sample period starts in 2009, as Weibo was launched that August. Following others, we exclude firm observations with missing data, special treatment, or in finance-related industries (N. Jeong, Kim and Arthurs, 2021; Marquis and Qian, 2014; Zhong, Ren and Song, 2021). The final sample consists of 7421 observations, including 2078 CEO and firm combinations.

To test our hypotheses, we obtain data from multiple sources. The CEO social media engagement data are collected from one of the most influential public platforms in China – Weibo, known as the Chinese Twitter. Weibo was launched in 2009 by Sina Corporation, a leading Chinese technology company. It is one of the most popular and influential social media platforms that dominates online social interactions and information communication in China.[1] Similar to Twitter, the global microblogging platform, Weibo serves as a microblog platform for Chinese netizens while international social media platforms like Twitter and Facebook are not available in China (Feng and Johansson, 2019). The public can post, comment, reply and repost microblogs to share opinions, and the length of texts is usually limited to 140 words. The CSR data are based on the Environmental, Social and Governance Database of Listed Companies (CESG) established by the Chinese Research Data Services (CNRDS) platform. Our firm- and executive-level data come from the China Stock Market and Accounting Research (CSMAR) database.

Measures

Dependent variables. We use CESG ratings to measure the social performance of firm observations. As a well-developed CSR rating database in China that has been widely used in recent years (Yang *et al.*, 2022), the CESG focuses on CSR evaluations of Chinese

[1] As reported by Weibo, its number of daily active users has been more than 220 million in the past 3 years, with monthly active users of 511 million in 2020, 573 million in 2021 and 586 million in 2022.

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listed firms by following the rules and framework of the famous KLD database. Differing from other Chinese CSR databases, the CESG includes multiple CSR pillars and dimensions to rate both socially responsible and irresponsible aspects of firms, i.e., CSR strengths and concerns. Specifically, the database reports the strength and concern ratings in six areas of CSR: product, charity and socially controversial issues, diversity, governance, employees and environment. Following previous studies (Chin, Hambrick and Treviño, 2013; Janani *et al.*, 2022; O'Sullivan, Zolotoy and Fan, 2021), our main dependent variable is *CSP*, measured by the net score of the total strength score and the total concern score for the firm in the fiscal year. The total strength (or concern) scores are calculated by summing strength (or concern) ratings in the six dimensions. For additional analyses, we also construct a set of dependent variables utilizing the comprehensive CESG data. For example, *CSR_strength* and *CSR_concern* are measured by the total strength and concern scores, respectively, so that both responsible and irresponsible performance are separately investigated. Similarly, to further measure social performance in specific dimensions, we also calculate the net scores in the six areas to construct the sub-dimensional measures, including *CSR_product*, *CSR_charity*, *CSR_diversity*, *CSR_governance*, *CSR_employees* and *CSR_environment*.

Independent variables. To measure CEO sociability by social media data, we first identify the CEO for each firm observation as documented in annual reports. With the list of 1081 CEOs, we use their names to search individual accounts on Weibo to check if the CEO has owned an account and, if so, when they registered the account. The search and information collection are carried out by the computer programming of web crawler to make an initial list of CEOs' Weibo accounts. As duplicate names are quite common, a CEO name may match multiple accounts; further work is needed to confirm the accurate account owned by the CEO. Thus, we manually check account information (e.g. account label, user verification and post contents) and then compare it with the CEO information to obtain the final CEO-Weibo account list. With this list, we construct our independent variable – *Social CEO* – a dummy variable taking the value 1 if the CEO has owned a Weibo account in the previous year of CSR rating, and 0 otherwise. Therefore, in line with the literature (Q. Wang, Lau and Xie, 2021; Weber Shandwick, 2014), the CEO with a Weibo account is a social CEO, who is more likely to have social interactions with the public.

Moderators. To test the moderating mechanism, two moderating variables are constructed by measuring the status and reputation of CEOs respectively – *CEO status* and *CEO reputation*. Based on the status literature, individual status can be measured in different aspects, such as economic, political and social status (Liu *et al.*, 2021; Weber, 1947). Since the wealth data of Chinese CEOs are usually nontransparent or inaccurate, we use CEO information in the political and social areas to measure CEO status. With China's institutional setting, political position is always regarded as a representative indicator of CEO status, as political connections suggest 'the prestige of the social and political resources' (H. Wu *et al.*, 2018, p. 171). For example, a Chinese CEO usually has a higher level of status in the firm and society if he or she holds a position in political institutions such as the National People's Congress (NPC), central or local government, the Chinese People's Political Consultative Conference (CPCC) or the Communist Party Committee (H. Li *et al.*, 2008; H. Wu *et al.*, 2018). In this study, we therefore measure *CEO status* by political position, and this moderator equals 1 if the CEO is an NPC deputy or CPPCC member (i.e. higher status), and 0 otherwise. We focus on these two specific institutions to investigate the social acceptance of CEOs, because their members are always viewed as people's representatives in China and widely acknowledged by the public.

The other moderator is *CEO reputation*, measured by the overall affectivity of media coverage related to the CEO (Deephouse, 2000; Wei, Ouyang and Chen, 2018). The media coverage data are collected from the *China Enterprise News* and the *China Entrepreneur* on the CNRDS platform,[2] the two most famous newspapers publishing news associated with firm executives. Specifically, building on the Janis–Fader coefficient of imbalance (Deephouse, 2000), we construct this moderator based on the formula below:

$$CEO\ reputation = \begin{cases} \frac{P^2-PN}{T^2},\ if\ P > N \\ 0,\ if\ P = N \\ \frac{PN-N^2}{T^2},\ if\ P < N \end{cases}$$

where P is the amount of positive media coverage about the CEO, N is the amount of negative media coverage about the CEO and T is the amount of total media coverage, including neutral coverage, about the CEO. Thus, the value of this moderator falls into the range −1 to 1, with −1 indicating completely negative coverage and 1 indicating completely positive coverage. The bigger this moderator is, the better reputation the CEO has.

Control variables. To rule out alternative explanations, we have controlled for both firm- and CEO-level factors. At the firm level, following previous research, we include *Age* (the number of years since the firm's establishment), *ROA* (return on assets), *Leverage* (ratio of

[2]This platform uses artificial intelligence algorithms, that is, the statistical approach based on a support vector machine to analyse the tone of news and categorize it as positive, negative or neutral.

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debt to assets), *Tobin's Q* (the firm market value divided by the book value of total assets), *SOE* (a dummy variable coded as 1 if the firm is ultimately owned by the state), *Ownership concentration* (the percentage of ten largest shareholders), *Misconduct* (1 if the firm has been reported for any misconduct (e.g. regulatory punishment) in the previous year, and 0 otherwise) and *CEO–chairman duality* (1 if the chairman is also the CEO, and 0 otherwise).

At the CEO level, we account for a set of characteristic variables including *CEO tenure* (the number of years that a CEO has been in office), *CEO education* (coded 1 for high school or below, 2 for college, 3 for bachelor's degree, 4 for master's degree, 5 for PhD), *CEO overseas* (1 if the CEO has overseas experience, 0 otherwise) and *CEO gender* (1 if the CEO is female, 0 otherwise), which are discussed as potential indicators of CSP in the upper-echelons literature (Bertrand, Betschinger and Moschieri, 2021; Ho *et al.*, 2015; Wei, Ouyang and Chen, 2018; Zhang, Xu and Chen, 2022; H. Zhu *et al.*, 2022). For the impact of CEO personality, we include the two most frequently discussed traits in prior research: hubris and narcissism. Following Tang *et al.* (2015), *CEO hubris* is measured as the difference between the numbers of times the CEO being described by the press useing terms suggesting confidence and that suggesting conservatism.[3] *CEO narcissism* is captured by CEO prominence in company press releases, as the number of times the CEO was mentioned by name in the company's press releases divided by the total number of the company's press releases (Al-Shammari, Rasheed and Al-Shammari, 2019; D. H. Zhu and Chen, 2015).

To alleviate the possibility of reverse causality, all time-varying moderators and control variables are lagged by 1 year. We also account for the reverse causality concern through some additional analyses for robustness (see Appendix A). The summary statistics and correlation coefficients are presented in Table 1. The sample mean of CSP indicates that the average CSR net score of our firm observations is 18.25. The mean of Social CEO is 0.03, suggesting that 3% of the CEO observations have a Weibo account in the given year. To exclude the concern of potential multicollinearity, we also calculate the value of variance inflation factors (VIFs) of our models and the highest VIF (2.79) is below the cutoff value of 10, suggesting that there is no multicollinearity issue.

Regression models. We propose that variations in CEO sociability will be reflected in variations in CSP within a

Table 1. Summary statistics and correlations

No.	Variables	Mean	SD	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10	11	12	13	14	15	16	17	18	19
1	CSP	18.25	6.25																			
2	CSR_strength	18.66	6.27	0.995																		
3	CSR_concern	0.41	0.64	−0.027	0.075																	
4	Social CEO	0.03	0.17	0.002	0.001	−0.013																
5	CEO status	0.15	0.35	−0.005	−0.005	0.002	0.039															
6	CEO reputation	0.04	0.21	0.078	0.080	0.028	0.059	0.096														
7	Age	17.85	5.86	0.198	0.197	−0.003	−0.010	−0.031	−0.046													
8	ROA	0.08	1.26	0.007	0.006	−0.011	−0.001	−0.001	0.000	0.019												
9	Leverage	0.48	0.20	0.082	0.091	0.090	−0.047	−0.017	0.025	0.069	−0.055											
10	Tobin's Q	1.90	2.78	−0.075	−0.076	−0.014	0.031	0.013	−0.010	0.007	0.079	−0.182										
11	SOE	0.55	0.50	0.012	0.015	0.023	−0.098	−0.161	0.007	−0.040	−0.019	0.246	−0.095									
12	Ownership concentration	0.60	0.16	0.153	0.152	−0.006	0.014	−0.025	0.057	−0.233	−0.013	0.001	−0.088	0.126								
13	Misconduct	0.17	0.37	0.024	0.079	0.054	−0.043	0.00	0.012	−0.034	−0.008	0.061	−0.045	0.044	−0.012							
14	CEO tenure	5.04	4.59	0.022	0.019	−0.033	0.038	0.209	0.062	0.112	−0.001	−0.011	0.023	−0.204	−0.257	−0.030						
15	CEO education	3.50	0.80	0.090	0.090	0.005	0.005	−0.005	0.022	−0.034	−0.011	0.061	−0.029	0.127	0.050	0.019	−0.004					
16	CEO-chairman duality	0.19	0.39	−0.002	−0.003	−0.016	0.112	0.084	0.024	−0.005	0.029	−0.109	0.059	−0.289	0.000	−0.026	0.049	0.045				
17	CEO oversea	0.07	0.26	0.084	0.083	−0.007	−0.004	0.002	0.003	0.033	−0.004	−0.028	0.013	−0.092	−0.022	−0.020	0.039	0.092	0.060			
18	CEO gender	0.05	6.22	0.032	0.030	−0.023	0.057	0.047	−0.004	0.029	−0.002	0.001	−0.001	−0.072	−0.001	−0.032	0.005	−0.030	−0.003	0.016		
19	CEO hubris	−1.62	6.71	0.086	0.083	−0.027	0.008	−0.033	0.031	0.022	0.003	−0.002	−0.007	0.078	0.045	0.008	−0.014	0.045	−0.046	0.013	−0.034	
20	CEO narcissism	0.11	0.18	0.020	0.018	−0.015	0.046	0.010	0.023	0.076	−0.008	−0.006	−0.026	−0.062	−0.041	−0.019	−0.004	0.010	0.030	0.004	0.019	−0.178

[3]A detailed description of this measure can be found in Tang *et al.* (2015). The confidence terms include 'confident', 'confidence', 'optimistic' and 'optimism'. The conservatism terms are 'reliable', 'cautious', 'conservative', 'practical', 'frugal', 'steady', 'not confident' and 'not optimistic'. Only the terms appearing within ten words of the CEO's name have been counted.

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focal firm. Thus, to account for the within-firm effects, a fixed-effect ordinary least squares (OLS) model is constructed to test H1 predicting the relationship between social CEOs and CSP. The model specification is

$$\begin{aligned} \mathrm{CSP}_{i,t} = {} & \alpha + \beta_0 \mathrm{Social\ CEO}_{i,t-1} \\ & + \beta_1 \mathrm{Control_variable}_{i,t-1} + \varepsilon_{i,t} \end{aligned} \quad (1)$$

where Control_variable is a vector of control variables including *Age*, *ROA*, *Leverage*, *Tobin's Q*, *SOE*, *Ownership concentration*, *Misconduct*, *CEO tenure*, *CEO education*, *CEO–chairman duality*, *CEO overseas*, *CEO gender*, *CEO hubris* and *CEO narcissism*. We also control for the firm, year and industry fixed effects in the model.

Meanwhile, to test our moderating mechanisms proposed in H2 and H3, we build a fixed-effect OLS model as specified below:

$$\begin{aligned} \mathrm{CSP}_{i,t} = {} & \alpha + \beta_0 \mathrm{Social\ CEO}_{i,t-1} \\ & + \beta_1 Inter_variable_{i,t-1} \\ & + \beta_2 Control_variables_{i,t-1} + \varepsilon_{i,t} \end{aligned} \quad (2)$$

where Inter_variable represents the interaction terms, including *Social CEO* × *CEO status* and *Social CEO* × *CEO reputation*. The firm, year and industry fixed effects are also included in the models.

Results

Main results

Table 2 reports the empirical results for testing our hypotheses. In Model 1, we first examine the impact of social CEOs on CSP by regressing our dependent variable *CSP* on *Social CEO* and all the control variables. The results show that the coefficient of *Social CEO* is positive and significant at the 1% level. The coefficient estimate suggests that, ceteris paribus, firms with a social CEO have a higher rating in CSP, and in particular an increase of 1.229 on average over firms without a social CEO. We therefore obtain empirical support for H1. Further, H2 and H3 predict that the positive relationship between CEO sociability and CSP is amplified when the CEOs have higher levels of status or reputation. To test this set of hypotheses, we include the corresponding moderators and interaction terms as shown in Models 2 and 3. The coefficient of *Social CEO* × *CEO status* is positive and significant ($p < 0.1$), indicating that the positive effect of CEO sociability on CSP is stronger for CEOs of higher status. Likewise, the coefficient of *Social CEO* × *CEO reputation* is significantly positive ($p < 0.05$), suggesting that an increase in CEO reputation can strengthen the positive relationship between social CEO and CSP. The empirical results provide support for our moderating hypotheses.

Table 2. Empirical results for the main analysis

Variables	Model 1 CSP	Model 2 CSP	Model 3 CSP
Social CEO	1.229***	0.857*	0.977**
	(2.718)	(1.697)	(2.104)
Social CEO × CEO status		1.784*	
		(1.662)	
Social CEO × CEO reputation			1.792**
			(2.409)
CEO status	0.337	0.272	0.342
	(1.357)	(1.085)	(1.377)
CEO reputation	0.292	0.293	0.168
	(1.526)	(1.534)	(0.846)
Age	1.044	1.066	1.045
	(0.443)	(0.452)	(0.444)
ROA	0.116*	0.111	0.112*
	(1.710)	(1.635)	(1.649)
Leverage	0.426	0.416	0.422
	(0.956)	(0.934)	(0.947)
Tobin's Q	−0.056	−0.053	−0.053
	(−1.626)	(−1.553)	(−1.556)
SOE	0.208	0.233	0.210
	(0.751)	(0.839)	(0.758)
Ownership concentration	1.758***	1.765***	1.762***
	(2.909)	(2.920)	(2.916)
Misconduct	−0.133	−0.139	−0.138
	(−0.726)	(−0.758)	(−0.755)
CEO tenure	−0.015	−0.014	−0.014
	(−1.128)	(−1.111)	(−1.093)
CEO education	0.061	0.063	0.059
	(0.631)	(0.652)	(0.611)
CEO–chairman duality	−0.402**	−0.400**	−0.403**
	(−2.450)	(−2.442)	(−2.458)
CEO overseas	0.525**	0.516**	0.530**
	(2.184)	(2.148)	(2.203)
CEO gender	0.393	0.386	0.403
	(1.434)	(1.412)	(1.472)
CEO hubris	0.006	0.006	0.006
	(0.884)	(0.878)	(0.885)
CEO narcissism	0.200	0.210	0.202
	(0.702)	(0.734)	(0.709)
Firm fixed effects	Yes	Yes	Yes
Year fixed effects	Yes	Yes	Yes
Industry fixed effects	Yes	Yes	Yes
Constant	0.269	−0.013	0.249
	(0.009)	(−0.000)	(0.009)
Observations	7421	7421	7421
Within R^2	0.318	0.318	0.319

Note: t Statistics in parentheses. * $p < 0.1$; ** $p < 0.05$; *** $p < 0.01$.

In addition, the moderating effects of CEO status and reputation are further illustrated graphically in Figures 1 and 2. It is observed that the positive effect of social CEOs on CSP is stronger under conditions of high CEO status (Figure 1) and high CEO reputation (Figure 2), suggesting that higher status or reputation strengthen the positive relationship.

Additional analyses

To further explore the relationship between social CEOs and CSR, we carry out an extensive array of additional

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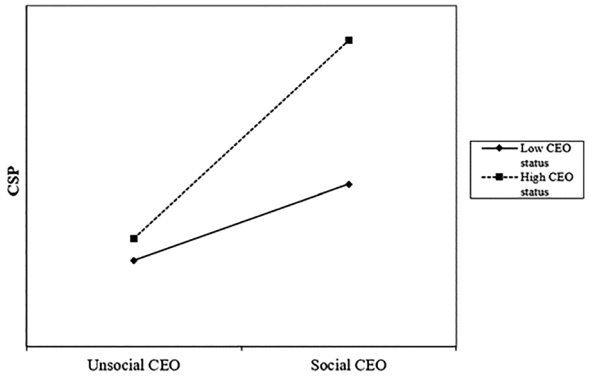


Figure 1. The impact of CEO status on the link between social CEO and CSP

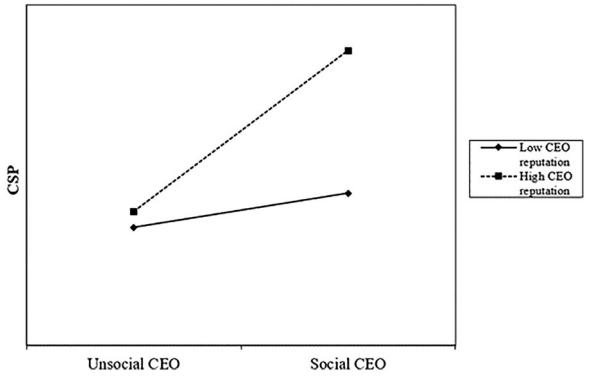


Figure 2. The impact of CEO reputation on the link between social CEO and CSP

tests to look at CEO social media engagement behaviour as well as the different CSR areas.

The posting behaviour of social CEOs. First, for social CEOs in our sample, besides a dummy variable measured by CEO presence on social media, the degrees of their sociability can be further investigated according to their engagement behaviour on social media. Therefore, we conduct a supplemental analysis with the subsample of social CEOs (N = 229) to explore whether the degree of CEO sociability can predict CSP as well. The new independent variable is *CEO posts*, measured as the natural logarithm of one plus the number of posts created by the CEO in the given year (the mean number of posts is 80.26, SD = 216.25). We posit that more CEO posts indicate a higher degree of sociability, because the CEO interacts more actively with the online public. Following our main hypothesis, CEO posts as a proxy of CEO sociability degree is expected to have a positive effect on CSP. Table 3 presents the empirical results for this additional analysis. As shown in Model 1, the coefficient of *CEO posts* is positive and significant at the 1% level, suggesting that CSP is better for social CEOs with more posts. We also test the moderating mechanisms regarding social evaluation of CEOs in Models 2 and 3. The coefficient of *CEO posts* × *CEO status* is positive and significant ($p < 0.05$), and the coefficient of *CEO posts* × *CEO reputation* is positive although not significant. The results are basically consistent with our main results, suggesting that higher levels of social evaluation can strength the relationship between CEO sociability degree and CSP. Overall, our findings provide further support for all our hypotheses by focusing on the degree of CEO sociability.

Furthermore, as there could be different post topics, we conduct supplemental content analysis of all the posts to explore the mechanism between CEO posts and CSP. To do this, all the posts have been reviewed and manually categorized as CSR-related or CSR-unrelated posts. We then construct two alternative explanatory variables, *CSR-related posts* and *CSR-unrelated posts*, measured respectively by the natural logarithm of one plus the number of CSR-related posts and the natural logarithm of one plus the number of CSR-unrelated posts in the given year. The empirical results using the measures in Models 4 and 5 show that both coefficients, for CSR-related posts ($\beta = 1.659$, $p < 0.01$) and CSR-unrelated posts ($\beta = 0.409$, $p < 0.05$), are significantly positive. The results not only provide robustness for our findings above, but also suggest that the CSR-related posting of social CEOs plays a stronger role in increasing CSP than CSR-unrelated posting. Accordingly, we propose that a higher percentage of CSR content in CEO posts also shows a more intense CSR focus of the social CEO, which may strengthen the relationship between CEO posts and CSP. Thus, we construct a moderator variable, *CSR orientation*, to measure the percentage of CSR-related posts in CEO posts. The results in Model 6, testing the moderating effect, support our prediction that the positive effect of CEO posts on CSP is more prominent when there is a higher percentage of CSR-related posts.

Lastly, to address the potential selection issues of CEO social media use resulting from social evaluation, we utilize Heckman's two-stage approach (Heckman, 1979) to check the robustness. In the first stage, CEO status and CEO reputation are treated as the exclusion restriction to construct the inverse Mills' ratio (IMR) in the probit model that affects the likelihood of CEO social media presence (Heckman, 1979). Then, the IMR is added to the regression models predicting the relation between CEO posts and CSP as the second-stage analysis. After adjusting the potential selection bias by introducing the IMR, the estimation results testing the effect of CEO posts on CSP are shown in Model 7. We can see that the coefficient of CEO posts is still significantly positive ($p < 0.01$), so our findings are robust after considering selection issues.

The decomposition of CSR. As suggested by CSR research, firm social performance can be deconstructed, considering its socially responsible and irresponsible

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Table 3. Empirical results for additional analysis on CEO posting behaviour

Variables	Model 1 CSP	Model 2 CSP	Model 3 CSP	Model 4 CSP	Model 5	Model 6 CSP	Model 7 CSP
CEO posts	0.480***	0.242	0.446**			0.216	0.409***
	(2.723)	(1.221)	(2.428)			(1.138)	(2.591)
CSR-related posts				1.659***			
				(3.780)			
CSR-unrelated posts					0.409**		
					(2.379)		
CEO posts × CEO status		0.979**					
		(2.548)					
CEO status		−0.194					
		(−0.154)					
CEO posts × CEO reputation			0.352				
			(0.766)				
CEO reputation			1.115				
			(0.702)				
CEO posts × CSR orientation						11.917*	
						(1.674)	
CSR orientation						−24.654	
						(−1.040)	
IMR							−3.077
							(−1.206)
Control variables	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Firm fixed effects	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Year fixed effects	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Industry fixed effects	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Constant	−4.647	−1.110	−5.016	9.432**	9.583**	9.594**	16.390**
	(−0.815)	(−0.194)	(−0.882)	(2.401)	(2.379)	(2.386)	(2.192)
Observations	229	229	229	229	229	229	229
Within R^2	0.460	0.478	0.463	0.588	0.493	0.504	0.481

Note: t Statistics in parentheses. * $p < 0.1$; ** $p < 0.05$; *** $p < 0.01$.

Table 4. Empirical results for CSR strength/concern as dependent variables

Variables	Model 1 CSR strength	Model 2 CSR concern
Social CEO	1.219***	−0.052
	(2.731)	(−0.761)
Control variables	Yes	Yes
Firm fixed effects	Yes	Yes
Year fixed effects	Yes	Yes
Industry fixed effects	Yes	Yes
Constant	2.318	1.959
	(0.082)	(0.454)
Observations	7421	7421
Within R^2	0.433	0.027

Note: t Statistics in parentheses. * $p < 0.1$; ** $p < 0.05$; *** $p < 0.01$.

aspects (O'Sullivan, Zolotoy and Fan, 2021; Tang *et al.*, 2015). Accordingly, to corroborate the mechanism underpinning our findings about the impact of social CEOs on CSP, we replace the dependent variable in Equation (1) with *CSR strength* and *CSR concern*, respectively, as shown in Models 1 and 2 of Table 4. The coefficient of *Social CEO* in Model 1 is positive and significant ($p < 0.01$); it is negative but not significant in Model 2. This indicates that CEO sociability significantly elevates socially responsible performance, while not significantly alleviating CSR concerns. The findings here reveal the asymmetric influence of CEO sociability on socially responsible and irresponsible behaviour of the firm. We reason that compared with addressing CSR concerns, engaging in good deeds can better respond to the social influence and relatedness needs of social CEOs. Given that firms usually report less on their CSR concerns while emphasizing their CSR strengths (Yang *et al.*, 2022), reducing irresponsible behaviour may play only a marginal role in improving CEO image and bonding with stakeholders. Therefore, this additional analysis suggests that social CEOs improve CSP mainly by enhancing positive aspects of CSR rather than by restraining negative aspects.

As scholars have also called for the investigation of different dimensions of CSR (Orlitzky *et al.*, 2017; H. Wang *et al.*, 2016), we conduct analyses to test the possibly heterogeneous impacts of social CEOs on six areas of CSR. We first carry out content analysis on the posts of social CEOs to investigate which group of stakeholders are more likely to be targeted by social CEOs. The CEO posts mentioning firm stakeholders have been manually sorted into different groups (some posts may include more than one stakeholder

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Table 5. Empirical results for additional analysis of different CSR dimensions

Variables	Model 1 CSR_product	Model 2 CSR_charity	Model 3 CSR_diversity	Model 4 CSR_governance	Model 5 CSR_employees	Model 6 CSR_environment
Social CEO	0.321*	0.077	0.038	0.243**	0.257	0.257
	(1.759)	(0.493)	(0.402)	(1.985)	(1.623)	(1.623)
Control variables	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Year fixed effects	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Industry fixed effects	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Constant	4.550	3.609	−4.405	−8.059	11.614	11.614
	(0.392)	(0.364)	(−0.727)	(−1.036)	(1.154)	(1.154)
Observations	7421	7421	7421	7421	7421	7421
Within R^2	0.070	0.266	0.251	0.437	0.250	0.085

Note: t Statistics in parentheses. * $p < 0.1$; ** $p < 0.05$; *** $p < 0.01$.

group), including consumers (33.80% of posts), minority groups (2.19%), local community (11.13%), investors (38.37%), employees (10.34%) and the general public (13.92%). We can see that social CEOs use social media to reach consumers and investors mostly, while less effort is put into managing relations with other groups. The reason behind this might be that consumers and investors, as core stakeholders, are the more active groups on social media (Chu, Chen and Gan, 2020; Lee, Hutton and Shu, 2015; Zhou *et al.*, 2021). The results in Table 5 further show the empirical results on how social CEOs influence firm performance in different CSR dimensions. The dependent variables of Models 1 to 6 are *CSR_product*, *CSR_charity*, *CSR_diversity*, *CSR_governance*, *CSR_employees* and *CSR_environment*, respectively. The coefficient of *Social CEO* is positive and significant at the 10% level in Model 1, so firms with social CEOs are found to have better performance in terms of product dimension responsibility (e.g. product satisfaction and product safety). Similarly, the coefficients of Social CEO in Model 4 show that firms with social CEOs perform significantly better in terms of social responsibility in corporate governance ($p < 0.05$). Hence, our results are in line with the content analysis above and suggest that firms with social CEOs are more likely to take social responsibility, specifically towards consumers and investors.

Firm and industry heterogeneity. In addition to the CEO-level heterogeneity discussed in our conceptual framework, there is also potential firm- and industry-level heterogeneity within the impact of social CEOs on CSP. At the firm level, with the close relation between social performance and economic performance (Y.-C. Jeong and Kim, 2019; Oliver, 1991), a further analysis is conducted to examine the mechanism with *Tobin's Q* as the moderator. We argue that when the firm's market performance is more positive, the ability of social CEOs to improve CSP tends to be stronger. Similarly, since the competitive pressures of the industry might further activate CEOs' willingness to engage firms in CSR (Dupire and M'Zali, 2018), the other moderator at the industry level is constructed as *Industry concentration* to account for product market competition, measured by the sum of the market share of the four biggest firms in sales among all firms in the same industry and same year (Kim and Lu, 2011). Table 6 presents the results for firm and industry heterogeneity. The coefficient of the interaction term between *Social CEO* and *Tobin's Q* is significantly positive ($p < 0.01$), suggesting that more positive financial performance could strengthen the positive relation between social CEOs and CSP. Likewise, the coefficient *Social CEO* × Industry concentration is significantly negative ($p < 0.01$), indicating that when the market competition is higher, the positive impact of social CEOs on CSP is strengthened, which supports our prediction of the impact of market competition.

Table 6. Empirical results for additional heterogeneity tests

Variables	Model 1 CSP	Model 2 CSP
Social CEO	1.022**	5.613***
	(2.147)	(4.017)
Social CEO × Tobin's Q	0.093*	
	(1.657)	
Tobin's Q	−0.105**	
	(−2.329)	
Social CEO × Industry concentration		−6.677***
		(−3.289)
Industry concentration ratio		1.640**
		(2.005)
Control variables	Yes	Yes
Firm fixed effects	Yes	Yes
Year fixed effects	Yes	Yes
Industry fixed effects	Yes	Yes
Constant	0.502	−0.803
	(0.017)	(−0.028)
Observations	7421	7421
Within R^2	0.318	0.319

Note: t Statistics in parentheses. * $p < 0.1$; ** $p < 0.05$; *** $p < 0.01$.

Alternative measure for the dependent variable. Apart from the CESG database, there is another well-established database for Chinese CSR research named

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Table 7. Empirical results for alternative dependent variable

Variables	Model 1 RKS score	Model 2 RKS score	Model 3 RKS score
Social CEO	2.119**	1.090	1.605*
	(2.289)	(1.052)	(1.658)
Social CEO × CEO status		4.536**	
		(2.162)	
CEO status		0.270	
		(0.522)	
Social CEO × CEO reputation			2.652*
			(1.782)
CEO reputation			−0.024
			(−0.068)
Control variables	Yes	Yes	Yes
Firm fixed effects	Yes	Yes	Yes
Year fixed effects	Yes	Yes	Yes
Industry fixed effects	Yes	Yes	Yes
Constant	15.853***	15.692***	15.862***
	(11.380)	(11.204)	(11.389)
Observations	5126	5126	5126
Within R^2	0.308	0. 309	0.309

Note: t Statistics in parentheses. * $p < 0.1$; ** $p < 0.05$; *** $p < 0.01$.

RKS ratings (S. Li and Lu, 2020; Luo, Wang and Zhang, 2017; McGuinness, Vieito and Wang, 2017). Similarly, RKS is an independent rating agency aimed at CSR evaluation in China. RKS reports an annual CSR score (0–100) for each firm issuing CSR reports by evaluating the firm's overall social contribution, the content and quality of CSR reports, and so on. With this alternative database, we reconstruct a dependent variable - *RKS score* to replicate the main analyses, and the regression results are shown in Table 7. In line with prior results, the coefficient of *Social CEO* in Model 1 is positive and significant at the 5% level, suggesting that firms with social CEOs have higher CSR scores. The coefficients of interaction terms in Models 2 and 3 are also significantly positive, consistent with previous findings that support our moderating hypotheses.

Discussion and conclusion

In this study, we build on an upper-echelons perspective of CSR to explore how CEO sociability is reflected in CSP. Drawing on the insights from the social media use and leadership literature, we develop a needs–affordances–consequences approach for social CEOs to explain their motives and ability to improve their firm's social performance. Using a large sample of Chinese listed firms and social media data from Weibo, we find that firms with social CEOs who are interacting with the public on social media perform better at CSR than firms without social CEOs. The positive relationship is also found to be stronger when CEOs have higher social status or reputation.

Theoretical implications

This work makes several contributions. First, we extend the literature on the antecedents to CSR. Building on upper-echelons theory, prior CSR work has examined CEO characteristics including demographical features, experiences and a few personalities as the predictors of corporate social outcomes (Bouzouitina, Khaireddine and Jarboui, 2021; Ho *et al.*, 2015; Janani *et al.*, 2022; Lewis, Walls and Dowell, 2014; McGuinness, Vieito and Wang, 2017; O'Sullivan, Zolotoy and Fan, 2021; Petrenko *et al.*, 2016; Tang *et al.*, 2015; Zhang, Xu and Chen, 2022). In particular, while explaining the impact of executive personalities on CSP, the vast majority of studies have been focused on the core self-evaluation personalities showing CEOs' perception of themselves – such as hubris, narcissism and overconfidence (Bouzouitina, Khaireddine and Jarboui, 2021; Petrenko *et al.*, 2016; Tang *et al.*, 2015), which are regarded as the 'common' traits of firm leaders. Apart from the self-concept characteristics, sociability, which highlights the personality trait of interaction with society, can also be found in CEOs (Erdoğmuş and Esen, 2018; Heavey *et al.*, 2020; Weber Shandwick, 2014), while little is known about its impact on CSP. The present study explores the impact of CEO sociability on firm social behaviour, and thereby demonstrates an important but unstudied managerial characteristic that shapes CSR based on the upper-echelons theory.

Second, we provide a new conceptual understanding of the nascent literature on CEO social media use and firm outcomes. Inspired by social media's role in information dissemination, some studies have addressed the implications of CEO social media engagement for firm-level outcomes, such as capital market performance and firm acquisition strategies (Elliott, Grant and Hodge, 2018; Feng and Johansson, 2019; Q. Wang, Lau and Xie, 2021). However, its implications have not been extended to firm decisions and behaviour in a social context, and the question of how CEO social media engagement influences CSR remains unanswered. To address this question, we use an upper-echelons lens on CEO social media engagement as the manifestation of CEO sociability. Our findings suggest that, in addition to the effect on firm outcomes in the financial domain, CEO social media engagement also reflects their willingness and ability of social contribution, thus shaping firms' social outcomes.

Lastly, our comprehensive needs–affordances–consequences approach to social CEOs also contributes to the social media and leadership literature. With the rise of social media, an extensive leadership literature has explored the antecedents or consequences of firm leaders' social media engagement (Heavey *et al.*, 2020; Huang and Yeo, 2018; Karaduman, 2013; Kietzmann *et al.*, 2011; Matthews *et al.*, 2022; Mudambi, Sinha

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and Taylor, 2019). Meanwhile, due to their focus on certain causes or consequences of leaders' social media engagement (e.g. facilitating communication or building bonds), these studies usually provide an incomplete picture of CEO social media engagement regarding their motivations and ability. As a result, 'strategy theory and research on the social media engagements of strategic leaders remain disjointed' (Heavey *et al.*, 2020, p. 1492), leading to the recent call for a rich and comprehensive framework for understanding leadership through social media use (Matthews *et al.*, 2022). To answer this call, we develop a needs–affordances–consequences framework by fusing views on social media use with leadership research. This approach to social CEOs explicates their psychological needs, acquired affordances and the subsequent consequences of using social media, thus providing an integrative approach for the literature.

Practical implications

This study also provides practical implications for firms and stakeholders. Since CSR has been gradually regarded as a necessary firm performance dimension (Aguilera *et al.*, 2007; Campbell, 2007), firms may pay closer attention to the social aspect traits of CEOs, and especially how CEO sociability might lead to stronger motives and abilities in social contribution. From the perspective of CEOs, social CEOs could be informed about the positive implications of their social engagement and better utilize social media affordances such as stakeholder communication for improving firms' social performance. For stakeholders, firm executives and leaders like CEOs used to be far away and unreachable, and this distance precluded the public from seeing and getting information about top managers and their firms. Nowadays, as a form of public exposure and social engagement, the social media use of firm executives can give cues to their inner personalities which may shape firms' social outcomes. Thus, with the advancement of the Internet, stakeholders might benefit from easier and closer investigations on firms and their leaders to make decisions.

Limitations and future research

There are several limitations of this study that give rise to opportunities for future research. First, we argue that CEO sociability is an important managerial characteristic affecting firm outcomes, and we rely on CEOs' behaviour regarding social media engagement as suggested by prior research for capturing CEO sociability. But the investigation and measure of CEO sociability deserves more discussion. If feasible, future upper-echelons research may adopt an interview-based approach to measure this managerial trait and also give more insights by exploring the underlying psychological mechanism driving sociability. Second, we only focus on firms' social outcomes to discuss the implications of CEO sociability, while some other firm outcomes could be influenced by social CEOs as well. For example, as social media engagement affords CEOs with unique advantages of information communication and relationship building (Elliott, Grant and Hodge, 2018; Heavey *et al.*, 2020); future research may extend the upper-echelons lens of CEO sociability to the explanation of firm innovation outcomes such as open innovation. Lastly, this work employs a sample of publicly listed firms from only one country for the empirical analysis, so we encourage future research to test the generalizability of our findings in other contexts, such as in other countries or on different social media platforms.

Appendix A

To partially alleviate the reverse causality issue that socially responsible firms are more likely to appoint a social CEO, we use lagged variables in our main analysis. For a robustness check, we conduct further analysis here to address this issue. In our panel sample, it is investigated that for firms previously without a social CEO but having one later, the presence of a social CEO usually results from CEO turnover. As a result, the social CEO appointment can be regarded as a treatment, which provides a methodological setting for an 'event study' to examine the dynamic treatment effect (Balasubramanian, Fang and Yang, 2021; McGuinness, Vieito and Wang, 2017).[4] Specifically, the treatment group comprises firm observations with a social CEO appointment and the control group consists of firm observations without such appointment. Building on Balasubramanian, Fang and Yang (2021), the dynamic treatment model is designed as follows:

$$\begin{aligned} \mathrm{CSP}_{\mathrm{i,t}} = {} & \alpha + \beta_0 Weibo^{t-2} + \beta_1 Weibo^{t-1} \\ & + \beta_2 Weibo^{t} + \beta_3 Weibo^{t+1} + \beta_4 Weibo^{t+2} \\ & + \beta_5 \mathrm{Control_variable}_{\mathrm{i,t}} + \varepsilon_{\mathrm{i,t}} \end{aligned}$$

where Weibo^{t-2}, Weibo^{t-1}, Weibo^{t}, Weibo^{t+1} and Weibo^{t+2} are dummy variables equal to 1 if the observed year of the firm is 2 years prior to the appointment, 1 year prior to the appointment, the appointment year, 1 year after the appointment and 2 years after the ap-

[4]A treatment is identified as social CEO appointment when a firm previously without a social CEO appoints a new CEO with a Weibo account. For the case that the same CEO registered a Weibo account during the appointment, it is not regarded as the appointment of a social CEO so is not identified as a treatment. As a result, we have identified 55 observations with this treatment.

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Table 8. Empirical results for dynamic treatment effect

Variables	CSP	
$Weibo^{t-2}$	0.893	(0.812)
$Weibo^{t-1}$	−0.469	(−0.630)
$Weibo^{t}$	0.422	(0.764)
$Weibo^{t+1}$	0.964*	(1.698)
$Weibo^{t+2}$	1.053*	(1.768)
Control variables	Yes	Yes
Firm fixed effects	Yes	Yes
Year fixed effects	Yes	Yes
Industry fixed effects	Yes	Yes
Constant	−22.740	(−1.404)
Within R^2	0.419	

Note: t Statistics in parentheses. * $p < 0.1$; ** $p < 0.05$; *** $p < 0.01$.

pointment, respectively, and 0 otherwise. With the estimation model above, the coefficients of dummy variables therefore suggest whether there are systematic differences between the treatment and control groups in CSP during the five observed times.

The results of the dynamic treatment effect model are reported in Table 8. The coefficients of $Weibo^{t-1}$ and $Weibo^{t-2}$ are not significant, indicating that the treatment and control groups show no significant difference in CSP, 1 or 2 years prior to the treatment. Therefore, the appointment of social CEOs in firms is not likely to be caused by the differences in CSP. By comparison, the coefficients of dummy variables 1 or 2 years after the treatment ($Weibo^{t+1}$ and $Weibo^{t+2}$) are significantly positive ($p < 0.1$), suggesting that the presence of social CEOs does increase subsequent CSP. Thus, we find that the better CSP is caused by the presence of social CEOs, but not vice versa.

We also supplement other analyses for checking reverse causality. First, we conduct the Granger causality test following prior research (Dupire and M'Zali, 2018), and the test shows that social CEO Granger causes CSP (Wald statistic = 4.362, p = 0.036), but not vice versa. For further robustness, we adopt the dynamic panel model below to test causal direction from CSP to social CEO:

$$\begin{aligned}\text{Social CEO}_{i,t} = \alpha &+ \beta_0 \text{CSP}_{i,t-1} + \beta_1 \text{CSP}_{i,t-2} \\ &+ \beta_2 \text{Social CEO}_{i,t-1} \\ &+ \beta_3 \text{Social CEO}_{i,t-2} \\ &+ \beta_5 \text{Control_variable}_{i,t} + \varepsilon_{i,t}\end{aligned}$$

where $CSP_{i,t-1}$ and $CSP_{i,t-2}$ represent the CSR score at time period t−1 and t−2, respectively, for firm i. Social $CEO_{i,t}$, Social $CEO_{i,t-1}$ and Social $CEO_{i,t-2}$ represent the social CEO dummy variable at time period t, t−1 and t−2, respectively, for firm i. In our estimation results, we observe that β_0 (p = 0.466) and β_1 (p = 0.174) are not significant, indicating that CSP increase does not cause the presence of a social CEO.

Conflict of interest

The authors declare that they have no conflict of interest.

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